

WEEK 20

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *Eph 1:1–14*

The mystery of the will of God

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, to the saints who are also faithful in Christ Jesus: Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places, even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him. He destined us in love to be his sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will, to the praise of his glorious grace that he freely bestowed on us in the Beloved. In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace which he lavished upon us. For he has made known to us in all wisdom and insight the mystery of his will, according to his purpose which he set forth in Christ as a plan for the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth. In him, according to the purpose of him who accomplishes all things according to the counsel of his will, we who first hoped in Christ have been destined and appointed to live for the praise of his glory. In him you also, who have heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and have believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, which is the guarantee of our inheritance until we acquire possession of it, to the praise of his glory.

Responsorial *Eph 1:5.6; Rom 5:2*

R: God has predestined us to be His adoptive children through the work of Jesus Christ, according to the consent of His will, to the praise of His grace,
* that God has given us in His beloved Son.

V: By means of our Lord Jesus Christ we have obtained the possibility to approach this grace in which we find ourselves.

R: that God has given us in His beloved Son.

Second Reading *Hom. 1:3*

Great thing is the forgiveness of sins,

but greater still is that it has been given through the blood of the Lord.

A reading from the “Commentary on the Letter to the Ephesians” of St. John Chrysostom, bishop

“He has predestined us to be His adopted sons”, wanting to fully manifest in this way the glory of His grace. “According to the consent of His will, he says, to the praise and glory of His grace that He has given us in His beloved Son” (Ep. 1, 5-6). If therefore He has gratified us in this way to the praise and glory of His grace so that it may be manifested, let us remain firm in it.

Why then does He want to be praised and glorified by us? Because in this way our love towards Him will be more fervent. From us in fact He does not desire anything else other than our salvation, not the glory, or anything else, and everything is fulfilled with this scope. In fact he who praises and admires the grace that has been given to him, will be more solicitous and attentive.

The Lord has done like one who reinstates immediately to flourishing youth a being marked by scabies, by the pestilence, from every type of sickness and discrepancy, already reduced to the extremity by poverty and hunger, rendering him more beautiful than all men, with a radiant face as if he was hiding the rays of the sun in the blaze of sparkling eyes. And after having brought him back into the flower of age, he would re-vest him in purple imposing on him the diadem and adorning him completely with the regal apparatus. In the same way the Lord has transformed our soul and has made it beautiful, desirable and loveable, to the point that the angels themselves desire contemplating it. In this way he has rendered us so pleasant as to become the object of His desire. He says in fact: “To the king your beauty will be pleasing” (Ps. 44, 12).

Consider how many wicked things we were saying before, and how many words pregnant with grace our mouths prophecy now. We do not love riches anymore, nor desire anymore the present goods but the heavenly ones and the things of heaven. We do not consider perhaps well educated and loveable that young man who to the elegance and harmony of the body unites the grace of eloquence? Thus are the faithful.

Do you see of what things those who have been initiated to the divine mysteries speak! What is more pleasing than that mouth that prophesies words worthy of admiration and, with pure heart and mouth, participates of the mystical table, with great splendour and faith? What is more sublime than those words with which we have renounced to the devil and have been numbered among the soldiers of Christ? And what is greater than that confession that preceded the bath and of that which followed? How many of us in fact have profaned the baptism, and groan so that it may be possible for us to recover it!

“Grace that He has given us in His beloved Son, in whom we have redemption through His blood” (Ep. 1, 6-7). And in what way? It is marvellous not only that He has given us His Son, but also the way in which He has given Him to us, that is letting Him be killed for us. It is an incredible paradox: He handed over His beloved for those who hated Him. Do you see therefore at what price He estimated us. If when we were closed in hate and were enemies he gave us His beloved, what will He not do now that we have been reconciled by His grace?

From the most elevated reality He descended to that most contemptible reality; while before He had spoken of adoption as sons, of sanctification and of the call to be immaculate, now He speaks also of sin; but he does not lower the discourse of the highest things to the lowest, rather from these he elevates the discourse to those. Nothing in fact is so great as the fact that for us the blood of the same God has been poured out; and it is greater than the adoption as sons and of the other gifts, given that He has not spared even His own Son. A great thing is the forgiveness of sins, but even greater is that it has been given thanks to the blood of the Lord.

Responsorial *Col 1:21.22; Rom 3:25*

R: Even you once were strangers and enemies with the mind intent on the wicked deeds that you were doing, but now He has reconciled you by means of the death of His body of flesh, * in order to present you holy, immaculate and irreprehensible before Him.

V: God has pre-established Him to serve as an instrument of expiation by means of the faith, in His blood.

R: In order to present you holy, immaculate and irreprehensible before Him.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 1: 1 – 18*

The Vanity of all things.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

The words of the Preacher, the son of David, king in Jerusalem. Vanity of vanities, says the Preacher, vanity of vanities! All is vanity. What does man gain by all the toil at which he toils under the sun?

A generation goes, and a generation comes, but the earth remains forever. The sun rises and the sun goes down, and hastens to the place where it rises. The wind blows to the south, and goes round to the north; round and round goes the wind, and on its circuits the wind returns. All streams run to the sea, but the sea is not full; to the place where the streams flow, there they flow again. All things are full of weariness; a man cannot utter it; the eye is not satisfied with seeing, nor the ear filled with hearing.

What has been is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done; and there is nothing new under the sun. Is there a thing of which it is said, "See, this is new"? It has been already, in the ages before us. There is no remembrance of former things, nor will there be any remembrance of later things yet to happen among those who come after.

I, the Preacher have been king over Israel in Jerusalem. And I applied my mind to seek and to search out by wisdom all that is done under heaven; it is an unhappy business that God has given to the sons of men to be busy with. I have seen everything that is done under the sun; and behold, all is vanity and a striving after wind.

What is crooked cannot be made straight, and what is lacking cannot be numbered.

I said to myself, "I have acquired great wisdom, surpassing all who were over Jerusalem before me; and my mind has had great experience of wisdom and knowledge." And I applied my mind to know wisdom and to

know madness and folly. I perceived that this also is but a striving after wind.

For in much wisdom is much vexation, and he who increases knowledge increases sorrow.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Qo 5, 14; 1, 14; 1 Tm. 6, 7*

R: Man having come out naked from the womb of his mother, naked will go back and he will not be able to take anything with him: * all is vanity and a chasing of the wind.

V: We have not brought anything into this world and nothing can we take away:

R: all is vanity and a chasing of the wind.

Second Reading. *Cent 1. C. 1, 4 – 5, 16 – 17. 23 – 24. 26 – 28. 30 – 40*

Without charity everything is vanity of vanities.

A reading from the “Chapters on charity” of St. Maximus the Confessor, abbot.

Charity is a good disposition of the soul, according to which one prefers no creature to the knowledge of God. It is impossible to attain a lasting possession of this charity if one has any attachment to earthly things.

He who loves God prefers knowledge of him to all things made by him; and by desire ceaselessly devotes himself to it.

If all things have been made by God and for God, he is nobler than all the things made by him; he who deserts God, the incomparably nobler, and devotes himself to inferior things shows that he prefers before God the things made by him. He that loves me, says the Lord, will keep my commandments; and this is my commandment that you love one another.

He therefore who does not love his neighbour does not keep the commandment. Nor is he that does not keep the commandment able to love the Lord.

Happy the man who is able to love all men equally.

He that loves God most certainly also loves his neighbour. Such a man cannot keep money, but, God-like, distributes it, giving to each one in

need.

He that in imitation of God does deeds of almsgiving knows no difference between evil and good, just and unjust, in regard to the needs of the body, but distributes equally to all according to their need, even though for his good intention he prefers the virtuous to the bad.

Not only by the distribution of money is a charitable intention made manifest; no, far rather by the distribution of the word of God and physical service of others.

He that genuinely renounces worldly affairs and in an unfeigned way serves his neighbour out of charity, quickly is freed from every passion and is made partaker of divine charity and knowledge.

He that has made divine charity his possession has no labour in following after the Lord his God, as Jeremiah says; rather, he bears nobly every hardship, every rebuke and insult, thinking no evil at all of anyone.

Do not say- exclaims Jeremiah-that you are the Lord's temple. Nor say: Mere faith in our Lord Jesus Christ can save me. For this is ineffective unless you also possess charity for him through good works. As to mere believing: "the devils also believe and tremble."

The work of love is the intentional doing of good to one's neighbour and long suffering and patience; also the use of things in due measure.

Responsorial *John 13:34; 1 John 2:10, 3*

R: I give you a new commandment: that you love one another, as I have loved you. * He who loves his brother, lives in the light.

V: From this we know if we have known Christ: if we observe his commandments.

R: He who loves his brother, lives in the light

YEAR A

Gospel *Mt. 15:21-28*

And Jesus went away from there and withdrew to the district of Tyre and Sidon. And behold, a Canaanite woman from that region came out and cried, "Have mercy on me, O Lord, Son of David; my daughter is severely possessed by a demon." But he did not answer her even a word. And his disciples came and begged him, saying, "Send her away, for she is crying

after us." He answered, "I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel." But she came and knelt before him, saying, "Lord, help me." And he answered, "It is not fair to take the children's bread and throw it to the dogs." She said, "Yes, Lord, yet even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters' table." Then Jesus answered her, "O woman, great is your faith! Be it done for you as you desire." And her daughter was healed instantly.

Third Reading *Lett. 7: 6-8*

The Lord gave the woman a reward for her faith

A reading from the "festive letters" of St. Athanasius, bishop

"Blessed are those who are hunger and thirst for justice, because they will be satisfied" (Mt. 5: 6). The saints and those who love to live in Christ must lift themselves up to the desire of this food and pray saying: "Like the deer yearns for running water, so my soul is thirsting for you, O God" (Ps. 41: 2).

We also, my brothers, must mortify our members on the earth and feed ourselves of the living bread with faith and love towards God; without faith, in fact, it is impossible to participate of this bread. The Saviour himself, calling all to himself says: "If any man is thirsty let him come to me and drink" (Jn. 7: 37) and immediately he began to speak of the faith, without which no one can draw near to that food: "He who believes in me, as Scripture says, from his breast shall flow fountains of living water" (Jn. 7: 37-38). For this he always nourished his disciples who had faith, with his words, and with the presence of his divinity he communicated life to them.

To that Canaanite woman instead, who still had not come to the faith, he did not deign to answer, even though she had a great need of his help. The Lord behaved in this manner certainly not out of contempt, otherwise he would not have gone near Tyre and Sidon, but rather because the woman did not as yet believe and being a foreigner could not boast of any right.

Justly he acted in this way, brothers; it was of no use in fact to pray before having received the faith, because her prayers had to be inspired by faith. He who turns to God needs above all to have faith in him; he then will grant that which has been asked for. The Apostle teaches us that "Without faith it is impossible to be pleasing to him" (Heb. 11: 6). To that woman therefore who is still without faith and all the more a foreigner, the Christ

expresses himself with that proverb: "It is not good to take the bread of the children and to throw it to the house dogs" (Mt. 15: 26).

But immediately, addressing himself to her who he had humiliated with such strong words and who, freeing herself from her paganism had reached the faith, does not treat her anymore like a dog but as a human being and says to her: "Truly great is the faith" (Mt. 15: 28). And as soon as she had believed, he gave her the reward of her faith, adding: "Let it be done as you desire. And from that instant her daughter was healed" (Mt. 15: 28).

Responsorial *Wisdom 1:1-2; Is 55:6*

R: Let honesty prompt your thinking of the Lord; seek him in simplicity of heart. * Since he is to be found by those who do not put him to the test, he shows himself to those who do not distrust him.

V: Seek the Lord while he is still to be found, invoke him while he is near.

R: Since he is to be found by those who do not put him to the test, he shows himself to those who do not distrust him.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Jn. 6: 51-58*

A reading from the Gospel of St. John.

I am the living bread which came down from heaven; if any one eats of this bread, he will live for ever; and the bread which I shall give for the life of the world is my flesh." The Jews then disputed among themselves, saying, "How can this man give us his flesh to eat?" So Jesus said to them, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of man and drink his blood, you have no life in you; he who eats my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day. For my flesh is food indeed, and my blood is drink indeed. He who eats my flesh and drinks my blood abides in me, and I in him. As the living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father, so he who eats me will live because of me. This is the bread which came down from heaven, not such as the fathers ate and died; he who eats this bread will live for ever."

Third Reading. *Book. 2, 3*

The Lord our God nourishes us for eternal life.

A reading from the “Commentary on Exodus” of St. Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

“As I, who am sent by the living Father, myself draw life from the Father, so whoever eats me will draw life from me. This is the bread come down from heaven; not like the bread our ancestors ate: they are dead, but anyone who eats this bread will live forever” (Jn. 6: 57-58).

I think that the manna is a veil and figure of the doctrine and of the gifts of Christ, that comes from above and has nothing that is earthly, but rather it is in complete contrast with the wicked desecration down here and it is a true food not only of men but also of the angels. In fact the Son, manifesting himself has manifested the Father to us, and through him we have known the relation that exists in the womb of the holy and consubstantial Trinity; we are thus guided through all the ways of virtue.

The upright and sincere knowledge of these things is nourishment of the spirit. And in truth the teaching has been given to us abundantly by Christ in full day.

The manna also has been given to the fathers in the splendour of the day and in the full brightness of light. In fact as it has been written, the day has already risen on us believers and the morning star has risen in all the hearts (cfr. 2 Pet. 1: 19). Christ, the sun of justice, offers us the spiritual manna and that which the material manna was a figure of, this is in reality.

Christ himself confirms this in a sure way when he says to the Jews: “Your fathers ate the manna in the desert and they are dead” (Jn. 6: 49). He is the bread that has come down from heaven so that he who eats it does not die: “I am the living bread that has come down from heaven. If anyone eats of this bread he will live forever and the bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world” (Jn. 6: 51). Our Lord Jesus Christ nourishes us for eternal life with his commandments of love and with his mystical gifts. He therefore is the true divine and life giving manna.

He who has eaten of this bread will not be subjected to the future corruption, and he will flee death. Not so those who eat the material manna: that in fact was not the bread of salvation, but only a figure of the reality. God then, making the manna rain down from heaven, commanded that each one was to gather as much as was enough for his hunger: if he wanted he could gather also for those who lived in his own tent. “Everyone must

gather enough of it for his own needs. Each of you will gather for those who share his tent. No one must keep any of it for tomorrow” (Ex. 16: 16, 19).

We need to be soaked in the divine and evangelical doctrine. Christ therefore distributed his grace equally to the small and to the great, and he nourishes everyone equally for life; and he wants to unite even the weaker to the others, desiring that the one and the other work for the brothers, in a way that they mutually help each other to become participants of the heavenly graces. It is what he himself says to the holy apostles: “Freely you have received, freely give” (Mt. 10: 8). Therefore those who had gathered more for themselves took care to distribute it to those who lived in the same tent, that is in the Church. In fact the disciples exhorted the weaker and incited them to the nobler things, communicating to everyone abundantly the grace received from Christ.

Responsorial. *Jn. 6: 49, 58, 51*

R: Your fathers ate the manna in the desert and they are dead. * He who eats this bread will live forever.

V: The bread that I will give is my flesh for the life of the world.

R: He who eats this bread will live forever.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 12: 49-57*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

"I came to cast fire upon the earth; and would that it were already kindled! I have a baptism to be baptised with; and how I am constrained until it is accomplished! Do you think that I have come to give peace on earth? No, I tell you, but rather division; for henceforth in one house there will be five divided, three against two and two against three; they will be divided, father against son and son against father, mother against daughter and daughter against her mother, mother-in-law against her daughter-in-law and daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law." He also said to the multitudes, "When you see a cloud rising in the west, you say at once, 'A shower is coming'; and so it happens. And when you see the south wind blowing, you say, 'There will be scorching heat'; and it happens. You hypocrites! You know how to interpret the appearance of earth and sky; but

why do you not know how to interpret the present time? "And why do you not judge for yourselves what is right?"

Third Reading. *Disc. 25*

I have come to bring fire to the earth.

A reading from the "Discourses" of Peter of Blois, presbyter.

The Christ, who has received the Spirit without measure, pours out his gifts on men, and does not cease to give: "From his fullness we have all received" (Jn. 1: 16) and "nothing will take us away from his heat" (Ps. 18: 7). He "has a fire in Sion and a furnace in Jerusalem" (Is. 31: 9). This is the fire that Christ has come to bring on the earth, and that appears above the apostles in tongues of fire, so that tongues of fire could preach a law of fire. Of this fire Jeremiah says: "There seemed to be a fire burning in my heart, imprisoned in my bones" (Jer. 20: 9).

In Christ the Spirit lived fully and sensibly; he then poured out on everyone a part of his Spirit, for which "to each one is given a particular manifestation of the Spirit for the common utility" (1 Cor. 12: 7). And he adds: there is a diversity of charisms and a diversity of ministries and operations, but one only is the Spirit (cfr. 1 Cor. 12: 4-6). Because of these different effusions of charisms, the Holy Spirit is called now fire, now oil, now wine, and now water. Fire because it always enflames with love, once lit does not stop burning, that is of loving ardently: "I have come to bring fire to the earth; and how I wish it were already burning!" (Lk. 12: 49).

The Holy Spirit is oil because of the different properties. It forms part of the nature of the oil, in fact, it remains floating over all other liquids; so also the grace of the Holy Spirit, which with the abundance of its goodness surpasses the merits and the desires of those who pray, is more precious than all the gifts and of all the goods. The oil is also a medicine because it calms pains; so also the Holy Spirit is truly oil because it is the comforter. Besides, by its nature, the oil does not mix with anything; so also the Holy Spirit is the pure source which cannot be united to anything extraneous.

Let us understand therefore why the Holy Spirit is named now as fire, now as oil. Twice it was given to the apostles: before the passion and after the resurrection. Observe how great in it is the source of ardour: it is not enough to pour out oil if it is not heated up, and it is not enough to draw near to the fire if it is not fed with oil. Burning with this fire, the apostles

“went out of the Sanhedrin happy to have been insulted” (Acts 5: 41). This then is the language of the prince of the apostles: If even you have to suffer for Christ, blessed are you (cfr 1 Pet. 3: 14). “To you has been granted the grace not only to believe in Christ, but also to suffer for him” (Phil. 1: 29).

The Holy Spirit is “the wine that gladdens the heart of man” (Ps. 103: 15) and is not poured into old wineskins. The Holy Spirit is water: “He who is thirsty – exclaims the Lord – let him come to me and drink” (Jn. 7: 37). The Holy Spirit is sweeter than honey: let us pray to him therefore in a spirit of humility, so that he may pour forth into our hearts a dew of blessing, an endless string of spiritual gifts, and an abundant rain of grace to purify our consciences. It infuses the oil of gladness and the fire of its love in our hearts, that is Jesus Christ, whom the Father consecrated and in whom he infused the fullness of the consecration and blessing, so that we could draw from this fullness. To him be honour and glory forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial.

R: The divine fire which does not burn but illuminates, which does not consume but shines, arrived unexpectedly: it found the hearts of the disciples like pure vases * and infused in them the gifts of the charisms.

V: It found them harmonious in charity and it illuminated them flooding them with divine grace.

R: and infused in them the gifts of the charisms.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 1: 15 – 23*

The prayer of Paul so that the faithful may be illuminated.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

For this reason, because I have heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus and your love toward all the saints, I do not cease to give thanks for you, remembering you in my prayers, that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give you a spirit of wisdom and of revelation in the knowledge of him, having the eyes of your hearts enlightened, that you may know what is the hope to which he has called you, what are the riches of his glorious inheritance in the saints, and what is the immeasurable greatness of his power in us who believe, according to the working of his great might which he accomplished in Christ when he raised him from the dead and made him sit at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority and power and dominion, and above every name that is named, not only in this age but also in that which is to come; and he has put all things under his feet and has made him the head over all things for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.

Responsorial. *Ep. 1, 17. 18; 1 Cor. 2, 12.*

R: God will give you a spirit of wisdom and of revelation in order to make you understand the hope to which He has called you. * And to which treasure of glory His inheritance among the saints encloses.

V: We have not received the spirit of the world, but the Spirit of God, so that we may know all that God has given us.

R: and to which treasure of glory His inheritance among the saints encloses.

Second Reading.

We have Christ who is our peace and our light.

A reading from the treatise “On Christian Perfection” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

“He is our peace, who has made both one” (Ep. 2, 14). Since Christ is our peace, we shall be living up to the name of Christians if we let Christ be seen in our lives by letting peace reign in our hearts. “He has brought hostility to an end” (cfr, Ep. 2, 16), as the apostle said. Therefore we must not let it come back to life in us in any way at all but must proclaim clearly that it is dead indeed. God has destroyed it in a wonderful way for our salvation. We must not, then, allow ourselves to give way to anger or bear grudges, for this would endanger our souls. We must not stir up the very thing that is well and truly dead, calling it back to life by our wickedness.

But as we bear the name of Christ, who is peace, we too must put an end to all hostility, so that we may profess in our lives what we believe to be true of Him. He broke down the dividing wall and brought the two sides together in Himself, thus making peace. We too, then, should not only be reconciled with those who attack us from without, we should also bring together the warring factions within us, so that the flesh may no longer be opposed to the spirit and the spirit to the flesh. Then when the mind that is set on the flesh is subject to the divine law, we may be refashioned into one new creature, into a man of peace. When the two have been made one we shall then have peace within ourselves.

The definition of peace is that there should be harmony between two opposed factions. And so, when the civil war in our nature has been brought to an end and we are at peace within ourselves, we may become peace. Then we shall really be true to the name of Christ that we bear.

When we consider that Christ is the true light far removed from all falsehood, we realise that our lives too should be lit by the rays of the sun of justice, which shine for our enlightenment. These rays are the virtues by which we cast off the works of darkness and conduct ourselves becomingly as in the light of day. Then, when we refuse to have anything to do with the darkness of wickedness and do everything in the light, we ourselves shall also become light and our works will give light to the others, for it is in the nature of light to shine out.

But if we look up on Christ as our sanctification, then we should keep ourselves free from all that is wicked and impure both in thought and in deed and so prove ourselves worthy to bear His name, for we shall be demonstrating the effect of sanctification not in words but in our actions and in our lives.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Lk. 1, 78. 79*

R: He will come to visit us like the sun that rises on high: * He will guide our steps on the way of peace.

V: He will give light to those in darkness and those who live in the shadow of death.

R: He will guide our steps on the way of peace.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 2: 1 – 3, 12 – 26*

The vanity of pleasures and of human wisdom.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

I said to myself, "Come now, I will make a test of pleasure; enjoy yourself." But behold, this also was vanity.

I said of laughter, "It is mad," and of pleasure, "What use is it?" I searched with my mind how to cheer my body with wine -- my mind still guiding me with wisdom -- and how to lay hold on folly, till I might see what was good for the sons of men to do under heaven during the few days of their life.

So I turned to consider wisdom and madness and folly; for what can the man do who comes after the king? Only what he has already done. Then I saw that wisdom excels folly as light excels darkness.

The wise man has his eyes in his head, but the fool walks in darkness; and yet I perceived that one fate comes to all of them.

Then I said to myself, "What befalls the fool will befall me also; why then have I been so very wise?" And I said to myself that this also is vanity. For of the wise man as of the fool there is no enduring remembrance, seeing that in the days to come all will have been long forgotten. How the wise man dies just like the fool!

So I hated life, because what is done under the sun was grievous to me; for all is vanity and a striving after wind. I hated all my toil in which I had toiled under the sun, seeing that I must leave it to the man who will come after me;

And who knows whether he will be a wise man or a fool? Yet he will be master of all for which I toiled and used my wisdom under the sun. This

also is vanity. So I turned about and gave my heart up to despair over all the toil of my labours under the sun, because sometimes a man who has toiled with wisdom and knowledge and skill must leave all to be enjoyed by a man who did not toil for it. This also is vanity and a great evil.

What has a man from all the toil and strain with which he toils beneath the sun? For all his days are full of pain, and his work is a vexation; even in the night his mind does not rest. This also is vanity. There is nothing better for a man than that he should eat and drink, and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God; for apart from him who can eat or who can have enjoyment? For to the man who pleases him God gives wisdom and knowledge and joy; but to the sinner he gives the work of gathering and heaping, only to give to one who pleases God. This also is vanity and a striving after wind.

Responsorial. *cfr. Qo. 2, 26; 1, 14; 1 Tm. 6, 10*

R: To the one who is pleasing to Him God concedes wisdom, science and joy; to the sinner He leaves the punishment of gathering and amassing. * All is vanity and a chasing of the wind.

V: To attach oneself to riches is the root of all evils; because of the unrestrained desire of it, some are tormented with many sorrows.

R: All is vanity and a chasing of the wind.

Second Reading. *Hom 5*

The wise man has his eyes in front.

A reading from the “Homilies on Ecclesiastes” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

If the soul should raise its eyes towards its Head, which is Christ, as Paul says, then it would be counted among the blessed as being sharp sighted, having its eyes where there is no shadow of evil. That same great Paul and any others as great as he fixed their eyes on that Head, as do all who live and move and have their being in Christ.

As it is impossible for anyone who lives in light to see the darkness, so it is not possible that he who fixes his eyes on Christ should lower them to dwell on vanities. For he who has his eyes on the Head – by Head we mean the origin of all things – has them fixed on all virtue – for Christ is the all complete virtue – on truth, on justice, on incorruptibility and on all that is

good. 'So the eyes of the wise man are on his Head, but the fool walks in darkness.' For he who does not put his lamp on the lamp stand but hides it under the base of his bed, turns that light into darkness for himself.

How many there are on the other hand who are engaged in lofty contests and are occupied in contemplation of things which really exist and yet are considered blind and useless in material things, as Paul boasted that he was, saying that he was a fool for Christ's sake. He did not exercise his prudence and knowledge on those things which enthrall us here below, for, as he said, 'We are fools for Christ's sake', as though to say we are blind to the life here below because we lift up our eyes and fix them on our Head. For this reason he lived without stool or table, poor, wandering, naked, suffering hunger and thirst.

And who would not have thought him pitiful seeing him in fetters, insulted with blows, plunged into the waves of the sea by shipwreck and led round in chains? But even whilst he suffered all this among men, he did not turn away his eyes, but always kept them steadfastly towards the Head saying, 'Who will separate us from the love of Christ, which is in Christ Jesus? Affliction? Distress? Persecution? Hunger, nakedness, danger or the sword? Which is as though to say, 'Who shall tear my eyes out from my head and bring them to what should be trodden underfoot? And he calls upon us to do the same when he gives the command, 'Occupy your minds with things that are above, in other words, have your eyes fixed on the Head.

Responsorial. *cfr. Ps. 122, 2; Jn. 8, 12*

R: See how the eyes of the servants are fixed on the hands of their masters.

* Our eyes, too, are fixed on the Lord our God, waiting for His mercy.

V: I am the light of the world; he who follows me, will not walk in the dark, but will have the light of life.

R: Our eyes are fixed on the Lord our God, waiting for His mercy.

Gospel. *Mt. 19: 16 – 22*

*If you want to be perfect sell all that you possess
and you will have a treasure in heaven.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And behold, one came up to him, saying, "Teacher, what good deed must I do, to have eternal life?" And he said to him, "Why do you ask me about what is good? One there is who is good. If you would enter life, keep the commandments." He said to him, "Which?" And Jesus said, "You shall not kill, You shall not commit adultery, You shall not steal, You shall not bear false witness, Honour your father and mother, and, You shall love your neighbour as yourself." The young man said to him, "All these I have observed; what do I still lack?" Jesus said to him, "If you would be perfect, **go, sell what you possess and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me.**" When the young man heard this he went away sorrowful; for he had great possessions.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 2: 1 – 10*

Sinners saved in Christ Jesus.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

And you he made alive, when you were dead through the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience. Among these we all once lived in the passions of our flesh, following the desires of body and mind, and so we were by nature children of wrath, like the rest of mankind. But God, who is rich in mercy, out of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead through our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved), and raised us up with him, and made us sit with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus.

For by grace you have been saved through faith; and this is not your own doing, it is the gift of God -- not because of works, lest any man should boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.

Responsorial. *Ep. 2, 5. 6; Jn. 3, 16*

R: From dead that we were because of sin, God has made us revive with Christ. * With Him He has also resurrected us and has made us sit in heaven with Christ Jesus.

V: God so loved the world that He gave His only Son.

R: With Him He has also resurrected us and has made us sit in heaven with Christ Jesus.

Second Reading. *Book 2*

For everyone there is only one identical grace of forgiveness.

A reading from the “Commentary on the Gospel of John” of Rupert of Deutz, abbot.

The baptism of Christ is the regal and priestly anointing, through which the anointed one, in preference of his equals is called Christ, a Greek name that in Hebrew means Messiah and in Latin signifies anointed. He is the only one to be consecrated fully in this way in order that He may consecrate the others one by one. And it is from His fullness, being the consecrated par excellence, He consecrates the adopted children who receive His same name of Christ, as the expression indicates: “He is the One who will baptise in the Holy Spirit” (Jn. 1, 33). The power of this baptism then does not have only one effect, but a double operation. In the first place Christ baptises in the Holy Spirit operating the forgiveness of sins. Other than this He baptises conferring also the ornaments of different graces. He Himself speaks about the forgiveness of sins on the day of the resurrection when, breathing on His disciples whom He had already purified from sins, washing them in His blood, He says: “Receive the Holy Spirit” (Jn. 20, 22). That the Holy Spirit was given to them for the forgiveness of sins He Himself attests when He immediately adds: “He whose sins you remit they will be remitted and He whose sins you do not remit will remain not remitted. (Jn 20, 23).

Of this donation of gifts with which He confers the ornaments of grace, Luke instead speaks of in the Acts of the Apostles saying: “John baptised with water, you instead not many days from now will be baptised with the Holy Spirit” (Act. 1, 5).

He baptises us in the Holy Spirit when, descending into the baptismal font, the invisible grace of the Spirit remits all the sins of those who are being baptised. In the forgiveness of sins there is no difference, but a unique and identical grace is given in an equal and uniform way to every one, that cancels all our iniquities and throws into the depths of the sea all our sins.

Instead with regard to the gifts of grace, the same measure is not given to all, but to some the faith is conceded, to others the language of science, or of wisdom, to others the variety of tongues, and to others the interpretation of tongues. “All these things are worked by the same and unique Spirit, distributing gifts to each one as He wants” (1 Cor. 12, 11).

In the saints of the New Testament we recognise, in these gifts, He who baptises, the luminous signs of this glorious baptism that, as we read, no one of them could receive before being baptised for the forgiveness of sins, except Cornelius and those of his household on whom, while Peter was still speaking, the Holy Spirit descended and they spoke in tongues magnifying God.

Of the fathers then of the Old Testament then, some received the gift of miracles, many the gift of prophecy, even though not having been baptised in the forgiveness of sins. But it is a certain thing that all were baptised when Christ died on the cross, and from his opened side gushed out a river of blood and water for the purification of the whole Church: that which had begun to exist from the origins of the world up to the hour of His death; that is from the first just man, Abel, up to the thief who on the cross, while from the side of Christ had not yet gushed out the river of that so abundant and wholesome flood, confessed that Christ is the Lord and, believing in His future kingdom, was ransomed by this immediate confession.

Responsorial. *Heb. 10, 22. 23; Mk. 16, 16*

R: With the heart purified from the wicked conscience and the body washed with pure water, let us maintain without wavering the profession of our hope, * because He who has promised it is faithful.

V: He who believes and is baptised, will be saved;

R: because He who has promised it is faithful.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 3: 1 – 22*

There is a time for every thing.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven: a time to be born, and a time to die; a time to plant, and a time to pluck up what is planted; a time to kill, and a time to heal; a time to break down, and a time to build up; a time to weep, and a time to laugh; a time to mourn, and a time to dance; a time to cast away stones, and a time to gather stones together; a time to embrace, and a time to refrain from embracing; a time to seek, and a time to lose; a time to keep, and a time to cast away; a time to rend, and a time to sew; a time to keep silence, and a time to speak; a time to love, and a time to hate; a time for war, and a time for peace. What gain has the worker from his toil?

I have seen the business that God has given to the sons of men to be busy with. He has made everything beautiful in its time; also he has put eternity into man's mind, yet so that he cannot find out what God has done from the beginning to the end. I know that there is nothing better for them than to be happy and enjoy themselves as long as they live; also that it is God's gift to man that every one should eat and drink and take pleasure in all his toil. I know that whatever God does endures for ever; nothing can be added to it, nor anything taken from it; God has made it so, in order that men should fear before him. That which is, already has been; that which is to be, already has been; and God seeks what has been driven away.

Moreover I saw under the sun that in the place of justice, even there was wickedness, and in the place of righteousness, even there was wickedness. I said in my heart, God will judge the righteous and the wicked, for he has appointed a time for every matter, and for every work. I said in my heart with regard to the sons of men that God is testing them to show them that they are but beasts. For the fate of the sons of men and the fate of beasts is the same; as one dies, so dies the other. They all have the same breath, and man has no advantage over the beasts; for all is vanity. All go to one place; all are from the dust, and all turn to dust again. Who knows whether the spirit of man goes upward and the spirit of the beast goes down to the earth? So I saw that there is nothing better than that a man should enjoy his work, for that is his lot; who can bring him to see what will be after him?

Responsorial. *cfr. 1 Cor. 7, 29. 31; Qo. 3, 1*

R: The time is brief; from now onwards, he who lives in this world, make use of it with discretion, * because the scene of this world will pass away.

V: Every thing has its moment, every undertaking under the heavens has its time;

R: because the scene of this world will pass away.

Second Reading. *Hom. 6*

Time to be born and time to die.

A reading from the “Homilies on Ecclesiastes” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

‘There is a time to be born and a time to die’ says the author. He has put down well at the beginning of his words these two related necessities, joining death with birth. For death follows inevitably on birth and every birth is brought to the dissolution of death.

‘There is a time to be born and a time to die’ he says. O that it may be granted to me to have a timely birth and an opportune death. No one can say that the Preacher shows this birth which is involuntary or this death which comes of its own accord as though there is therein the good action of virtue. For birth does not happen because of a woman’s act of will, nor does the event of death lie within the free will of the dying. No one can define as virtue or vice that which does not lie within our own power. We must therefore consider what is seasonable birth and what is timely death. I think that a birth is full-termed and not premature, when, as Isaiah says, a man brings to birth by the birth pangs of his soul his own salvation after he has conceived it by the fear of God. We are ourselves in a certain sense fathers of ourselves when by our good intention and our own free choice we conceive and give birth to ourselves and bring ourselves to the light. This we do as a result of receiving God into ourselves, when we have been made children of God, children of the power, children of the Most High. On the other hand we also turn ourselves into an abortion and make ourselves imperfect and sickly when there has not been produced in us, in the Apostle’s words, ‘the form of Christ’. For the man of God must be whole and perfect.

If then it is clear how we are born in timely fashion, so also it is clear how we die in timely fashion, as every time was for St. Paul the right time for a good death. He proclaims this in his own writings, confirming it as it were by an oath, when he says, ‘I die daily, by your boasting’, and elsewhere, ‘On your behalf we are afflicted by death everyday’. And we ourselves have the sentence of death in ourselves.

Indeed it is not in anyway obscure how Paul dies every day, who never lives to sin, who mortifies continually the limbs of his flesh, and bears about in his body the dying of the body of Christ, who is always being crucified with Christ, who never lives to himself, but has Christ living within himself – that in my judgement would be a timely death which has produced true life. ‘For’, God says, ‘I shall kill and I shall make alive’, which proves that to die to sin and to be made alive to the spirit is truly the gift of God.

Responsorial. *Deut. 32, 39; Ap. 1, 18*

R: It is I who give life and death, I who strike and heal, * and no one can liberate from my hand.

V: I have power over death and over hell.

R: and no one can liberate from my hand.

Gospel. *Mt. 19: 23 – 30*

*It is easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle,
than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of heaven.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And Jesus said to his disciples, "Truly, I say to you, it will be hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven. Again I tell you, it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God." When the disciples heard this they were greatly astonished, saying, "Who then can be saved?" But Jesus looked at them and said to them, "With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible."

Then Peter said in reply, "Lo, we have left everything and followed you. What then shall we have?" Jesus said to them, "Truly, I say to you, in the new world, when the Son of man shall sit on his glorious throne, you who have followed me will also sit on twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel. And every one who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or lands, for my name's sake, will receive a hundredfold, and inherit eternal life. But many that are first will be last, and the last first.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 2:11- 22*

The pagans reconciled with the Jews and with God.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

Therefore remember that at one time you Gentiles in the flesh, called the uncircumcision by what is called the circumcision, which is made in the flesh by hands -- remember that you were at that time separated from Christ, alienated from the commonwealth of Israel, and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world. But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near in the blood of Christ.

For he is our peace, who has made us both one, and has broken down the dividing wall of hostility, by abolishing in his flesh the law of commandments and ordinances, that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace, and might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby bringing the hostility to an end. And he came and preached peace to you who were far off and peace to those who were near; for through him we both have access in one Spirit to the Father.

So then you are no longer strangers and sojourners, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, in whom the whole structure is joined together and grows into a holy temple in the Lord; in whom you also are built into it for a dwelling place of God in the Spirit.

Responsorial. *Ep. 2, 14. 16. 17 – 18. 13*

R: Christ is our peace, He who has made of the two only one people, destroying in Himself the enmity. He has come to announce peace to you who were far away and peace to those who were close. * Through Him we can present ourselves, one and the other, to the Father in only one Spirit.

V: Now in Christ Jesus we have become close thanks to the blood of Christ.

R: Through Him we can present ourselves, one and the other, to the Father in only one Spirit.

Second Reading. Book 10

*Participating at the Eucharistic table, Christ in us
and we in Him become only one thing.*

A reading from the “Commentary on the Gospel of John” of St. Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

That it may be possible to unite ourselves spiritually to Christ with an interior disposition of perfect charity, with an upright and firm faith, with a sincere soul that desires virtue, is not at all denied by the doctrine of our dogmas: on the contrary we affirm that it teaches us exactly this.

Who in fact can doubt, by the strength of that doctrine, that Christ is the vine and we the branches, that from him and for him we have life, from the moment that Paul affirms: “Because there is only one bread, so we even though there are many, we are only one body” in Christ; “all of us in fact participate in only one bread” (1 Cor. 10, 17)?

Someone will tell us therefore the cause of the Eucharist and will explain the strength of it. For what reason does it enter into us?

Is it not perhaps because Christ lives in us also bodily, through the participation and the communion with his holy body?

It is evident: Paul in fact writes that “the Gentiles are called, in Christ Jesus, to participate in the same inheritance, to form the same body and to be participants of the promise by means of the Gospel” (Ep. 3, 6).

And in what way have they become the same body?

It is through the participation in the sacred Eucharistic table that they are made one body with him, as it happened for each of the apostles. Otherwise for what reason would he call members of Christ his members, that is those of everyone, like his own?

He writes in fact: “Do you not know that your bodies are the members of Christ? Will you therefore take the members of Christ and make them members of a prostitute? May it never be!” (1 Cor. 6, 15).

The Saviour himself says: “He who eats my flesh and drinks my blood lives in me and I in him” (Jn. 6, 56).

Worthy of attention is the significance of this work: Christ does not say that he will come in us only through a certain affective relationship, but also through a participation of nature. As in fact if one dissolves on the fire two pieces of wax, of the two he will make one only, in the same way, communicating with the body of Christ and with his precious blood, we become only one thing, he in us and we in him.

That which is corruptible by nature cannot be vivified in another way, if it is not united bodily to the body of him who by his very nature is the Life, that is the Only Begotten Son. But if you will not let yourself be persuaded by my words adhere with faith to Christ in person who says: “Truly, truly I say to you: if you do not eat the flesh of the Son of Man and do not drink his blood, you will not have life in you. He who eats my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life and I will raise him up on the last day” (Jn. 6, 53-54).

Responsorial. *1 Cor. 10, 16; Ps. 22, 5*

R: Is not perhaps the chalice of the blessing that we bless, a communion with the blood of Christ? *

V: Before me you prepare a table: my chalice brims over.

R: And is not perhaps the bread that we break, a communion with the body of Christ?

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 5: 9 – 6:8*

The vanity of riches.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

But in all, a king is an advantage to a land with cultivated fields. He who loves money will not be satisfied with money; nor he who loves wealth, with gain: this also is vanity. When goods increase, they increase who eat them; and what gain has their owner but to see them with his eyes? Sweet is the sleep of a labourer, whether he eats little or much; but the surfeit of the rich will not let him sleep.

There is a grievous evil that I have seen under the sun: riches were kept by their owner to his hurt, and those riches were lost in a bad venture; and

he is father of a son, but he has nothing in his hand. As he came from his mother's womb he shall go again, naked as he came, and shall take nothing for his toil, which he may carry away in his hand. This also is a grievous evil: just as he came, so shall he go; and what gain has he that he toiled for the wind, and spent all his days in darkness and grief, in much vexation and sickness and resentment?

Behold, what I have seen to be good and to be fitting is to eat and drink and find enjoyment in all the toil with which one toils under the sun the few days of his life which God has given him, for this is his lot. Every man also to whom God has given wealth and possessions and power to enjoy them, and to accept his lot and find enjoyment in his toil -- this is the gift of God. For he will not much remember the days of his life because God keeps him occupied with joy in his heart.

There is an evil which I have seen under the sun, and it lies heavy upon men: a man to whom God gives wealth, possessions, and honour, so that he lacks nothing of all that he desires, yet God does not give him power to enjoy them, but a stranger enjoys them; this is vanity; it is a sore affliction.

If a man begets a hundred children, and lives many years, so that the days of his years are many, but he does not enjoy life's good things, and also has no burial, I say that an untimely birth is better off than he. For it comes into vanity and goes into darkness, and in darkness its name is covered; moreover it has not seen the sun or known anything; yet it finds rest rather than he. Even though he should live a thousand years twice told, yet enjoy no good -- do not all go to the one place?

All the toil of man is for his mouth, yet his appetite is not satisfied. For what advantage has the wise man over the fool? And what does the poor man have who knows how to conduct himself before the living?

Responsorial. *cfr. Prov. 30, 8; Ps. 30, 15. 16*

R: Keep falsehood and lies far away from me, O Lord. * Do not give me either poverty or riches, but only the food that is necessary.

V: I trust in you, Lord; in your hands are my days.

R: Do not give me either poverty or riches, but only the food that is necessary.

Second Reading.

Search for the things of above.

A reading from the “Commentary on Ecclesiastes” of St. Jerome, presbyter.

‘Every man to whom God has given wealth and possessions and power to enjoy them, and to accept his lot and find enjoyment in his toil – this is the gift of God. For he will not much remember the days of his life because God keeps him occupied with joy in his heart.’ In comparison with the man who feeds upon wealth in the gloom of cares and hoards up perishable things with great heaviness of life, he says that man is better who enjoys his present joys. For in one case there is perhaps little pleasure in enjoyment; but in the other there is only a multitude of cares. And he gives the reasons why it is a gift of God to enjoy wealth. Because ‘he will not much remember the days of his life’. If God calls him away in the happiness of his heart, it will not be in sadness, he will not be troubled by anxiety, taken away in happiness and present pleasure. But it is better that spiritual food and spiritual drink should be understood, according to the words of St. Paul, and to see goodness in all one’s labour, for with great labour and zeal we can behold true goods. And this is our task, that we should rejoice in our zeal and our labour. Even though that is good, until Christ is manifest in our life it is not yet fully good.

‘All the toil of a man is for his mouth, yet his spirit is not filled. For what advantage has the wise man over the fool? And what does the poor man have who knows how to conduct himself before the living.’ All, over which men labour in the world, is consumed in the mouth, and munched by the teeth, it passes down to the stomach to be digested. For the little while that it delights the appetite, it seems to give pleasure while it is held in the mouth. When it has passed to the belly, there ceases to be any difference between sorts of food.

After all this, the soul of the eater is not satisfied; either because it again longs for what it has eaten, and both the wise man and the fool cannot live without food, and the poor man seeks for nothing except how he can keep the organism of his pitiful body alive and not die of hunger, or because the soul gains no advantage from the refreshment of the body and food is the same to the wise man and the fool alike and the poor man goes where he can see wealth.

It is better however that we should understand this about the writer of Ecclesiastes who, being learned in the heavenly scriptures, has his labour in

his mouth and yet his soul is not satisfied since he always longs to learn. In this matter the wise man has the advantage over the fool, that, when he feels that he is poor (by 'poor' we mean the man who is called blessed in the gospel), he hurries to find out those things which pertain to life, and he travels along that narrow, confined path which leads to life, and is poor in evil works, and knows where Christ dwells, who is life.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Sir. 23, 4. 5. 6. 1*

R: Lord, father and God of my life, do not put me at the mercy of impudent looks, drive concupiscence away from me. May sensuality and lustfulness not take control over me; * that I may not serve embarrassing desires.

V: Lord do not abandon me to their will, do not let me fall because of them:

R: that I may not serve embarrassing desires.

Gospel. *Mt. 20. 1 – 16*

You are envious because I am good.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"For the kingdom of heaven is like a householder who went out early in the morning to hire labourers for his vineyard. After agreeing with the labourers for a denarius a day, he sent them into his vineyard. And going out about the third hour he saw others standing idle in the market place; and to them he said, 'You go into the vineyard too, and whatever is right I will give you.' So they went. Going out again about the sixth hour and the ninth hour, he did the same. And about the eleventh hour he went out and found others standing; and he said to them, 'Why do you stand here idle all day?' They said to him, 'Because no one has hired us.' He said to them, 'You go into the vineyard too.' And when evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his steward, 'Call the labourers and pay them their wages, beginning with the last, up to the first.' And when those hired about the eleventh hour came, each of them received a denarius. Now when the first came, they thought they would receive more; but each of them also received a denarius. And on receiving it they grumbled at the householder, saying, 'These last worked only one hour, and you have made them equal to us who have borne the burden of the day and the scorching heat.' But he replied to one of them, 'Friend, I am doing you no wrong; did you not agree with me for a denarius? Take what belongs to you, and go; I choose to give to this last as I

give to you. Am I not allowed to do what I choose with what belongs to me? Or do you begrudge my generosity? ' So the last will be first, and the first last."

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 3:1 – 13*

Paul herald of the mystery of God.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

For this reason I, Paul, a prisoner for Christ Jesus on behalf of you Gentiles -- assuming that you have heard of the stewardship of God's grace that was given to me for you, how the mystery was made known to me by revelation, as I have written briefly. When you read this you can perceive my insight into the mystery of Christ, which was not made known to the sons of men in other generations as it has now been revealed to his holy apostles and prophets by the Spirit; that is, how the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel. Of this gospel I was made a minister according to the gift of God's grace which was given me by the working of his power.

To me, though I am the very least of all the saints, this grace was given, to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ, and to make all men see what is the plan of the mystery hidden for ages in God who created all things; that through the church the manifold wisdom of God might now be made known to the principalities and powers in the heavenly places.

This was according to the eternal purpose that he has realized in Christ Jesus our Lord, in whom we have boldness and confidence of access through our faith in him. So I ask you not to lose heart over what I am suffering for you, which is your glory.

Responsorial. *Ep. 3, 8. 12; Rm. 1,5*

R: To me who am the least known among all the saints, has been granted this grace of announcing to the Gentiles the special richness of Christ, * who gives us the courage to draw near in complete trust to God by the faith in Him.

V: We have received the grace of the apostolate to obtain the obedience to the faith on the part of all peoples, for the glory of his name.

R: who gives us the courage to draw near in complete trust to God by the faith in Him.

Second Reading. Hom. 8

The mystery of the Church.

A reading from the “Homilies on the Song of Songs” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Let us base ourselves on the Apostle in order to interpret these mysteries. In his letter to the Ephesians, when he presents us with that great appearance of God that comes about in the flesh, he says that not only to the human nature, but also to the principalities and to the powers that are in the heavens has been revealed the multiform and unfathomable wisdom of God, manifested with the coming of Christ in the midst of men. Thus says the text: “so that it may be manifested now in heaven, through the Church, to the Principalities and to the Powers, the multiform wisdom of God, according to the eternal design that He has actualised in our Lord Jesus Christ.” (Ep. 3, 10)

He “gives us the courage to draw near in complete faith to God through faith in Him” (Ep. 3, 12). Therefore it is exactly through the Church that the multiform and profound wisdom of God is manifested to the heavenly powers, which make us on the contrary to fulfil great and marvellous things. In what way in fact does life spring forth from death, justice from sin, blessing from cursing, glory from humiliation, power from weakness? In the beginning the heavenly powers had known a simple and uniform wisdom of God, which operated miracles according to its nature. Nor among the realities that could be seen was there anything different, because the divine nature, being power and strength, freely formed every creature with a simple act of will, imprinting the generative impulse to the nature of the things, and creating very beautifully all the things that sprung up from the same font of beauty.

Now instead, through the Church, the different and multiple nature of the divine wisdom appears clearly to them, as a result of the connection of the opposites, and precisely: the Word that is made flesh, the Life united to death, his wounds and bruises that heal our wounds. And again: how the power of the adversary is defeated by the weakness of the cross, how he who is invisible by nature is manifested in the flesh; how he being the

redeemer and the price of ransom itself frees the prisoners. He in fact hands over himself to death for us, without separating himself from life; he made himself servant, though remaining sovereign.

The friends of the Bridegroom, knowing through the Church all these and other similar realities, so different and multiform, were enriched in intelligence in order to discover in the mystery a new aspect of the divine wisdom: and if it is not too audacious to affirm, contemplating through the Bride the beauty of the Bridegroom, they remained greatly wondering, as if in front of an unexpected and incomprehensible reality.

God, in fact, who “no man has ever seen” as John says “nor can see” as Paul also affirms (1 Tm. 1, 16; cfr. Jn. 1, 18), has made the Church his body and, adding you to those who are called to salvation, builds it in charity, “so that we may all reach the state of the perfect man, in the measure of the full maturity of Christ himself” (Ep. 4, 13).

If therefore the Church is the body of Christ, and Christ is the head of the body, which outlines the face of the Church with its character, the friends of the Bridegroom, fixing their gaze on this reality, are rendered more capable of understanding: in fact through the Church they can see with more transparency the Bridegroom himself, who by his very nature is invisible to their sight. Like those who are not capable of looking directly at the sun, can above all see it reflected in water: in the same way they see in a clear mirror, that is in the face of the Church, the sun of justice, who is understood by the mind at least in the measure in which it appears.

Responsorial. *Ep. 4, 4- 5; 1Cor. 8, 6*

R: Only one body, only one Spirit, as only one is the hope to which you have been called, that of your vocation; * only one Lord, only one faith, only one baptism.

V: For us there is only one God, the Father, and only one Lord Jesus Christ;

R: only one Lord, only one faith, and only one baptism.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 7: 1 – 29*

Do not know more than what is necessary.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

A good name is better than precious ointment; and the day of death, than the day of birth. It is better to go to the house of mourning than to go to the house of feasting; for this is the end of all men, and the living will lay it to heart. Sorrow is better than laughter, for by sadness of countenance the heart is made glad. The heart of the wise is in the house of mourning; but the heart of fools is in the house of mirth. It is better for a man to hear the rebuke of the wise than to hear the song of fools. For as the crackling of thorns under a pot, so is the laughter of the fools; this also is vanity. Surely oppression makes the wise man foolish, and a bribe corrupts the mind.

Better is the end of a thing than it's beginning; and the patient in spirit is better than the proud in spirit.

Be not quick to anger, for anger lodges in the bosom of fools. Say not, "Why were the former days better than these?" For it is not from wisdom that you ask this. Wisdom is good with an inheritance, an advantage to those who see the sun. For the protection of wisdom is like the protection of money; and the advantage of knowledge is that wisdom preserves the life of him who has it.

Consider the work of God; who can make straight what he has made crooked? In the day of prosperity be joyful, and in the day of adversity consider; God has made the one as well as the other, so that man may not find out anything that will be after him. In my vain life I have seen everything; there is a righteous man who perishes in his righteousness, and there is a wicked man who prolongs his life in his evil doing.

Be not righteous overmuch, and do not make yourself over wise; why should you destroy yourself? Be not wicked overmuch, neither be a fool; why should you die before your time? It is good that you should take hold of this, and from that withhold not your hand; for he who fears God shall come forth from them all.

Wisdom gives strength to the wise man more than ten rulers that are in a city. Surely there is not a righteous man on earth who does good and never sins. Do not give heed to all the things that men say, lest you hear your servant cursing you; your heart knows that many times you have yourself cursed others.

All this I have tested by wisdom; I said, "I will be wise"; but it was far from me. That which is, is far off, and deep, very deep; who can find it out?

I turned my mind to know and to search out and to seek wisdom and the sum of things, and to know the wickedness of folly and the foolishness that is madness. And I found bitterer than death the woman whose heart is snares and nets, and whose hands are fetters; he who pleases God escapes her, but the sinner is taken by her.

Behold, this is what I found, says the Preacher, adding one thing to another to find the sum, which my mind has sought repeatedly, but I have not found. One man among a thousand I found, but a woman among all these I have not found.

Behold, this alone I found, that God made man upright, but they have sought out many devices.

Responsorial. *Prov. 20, 9; cfr. Qo. 7, 20; 1 Jn. 1, 8. 9.*

R: Who can say: I have purified my heart, I am cleansed of my sin? * There does not exist a man so just, who does only good and never evil.

V: If we say that we are without sin, we deceive ourselves. If we recognise our sins, God is faithful and will forgive us.

R: there does not exist a man so just, who does only good and never evil.

Second Reading. *Istr. 1 on the faith, 3 – 5*

The immense depth of God.

A reading from the “Instructions” of St. Columbanus, abbot.

God is everywhere, utterly vast, and everywhere near at hand, according to his own witness of himself; I am, he says, a God at hand and not a God afar off. The God we are seeking is not one who dwells far away from us; we have him within us, if we are worthy. For he resides in us like soul in body, if only we are sound members of him, if we are not dead in sins, if we are uninfected by the taint of a corrupt will; then truly does he reside in us who said, And I will live in them and move among them. Yet if we are worthy that he should be in us, then in truth we are vivified by him as his living members; for in him, as the Apostle says, we live and move and have our being. Who, I say, shall explore his highest summit to the measure of this unutterable and inconceivable being? Who shall dare to treat of the eternal source of the universe? Who shall boast of knowing the infinite God, who fills all and surrounds all, who enters into all and passes beyond all, who occupies all, who escapes all? Whom no man has ever

seen as he is? There let no man venture to seek the unsearchable things of God, the nature, mode and cause of his existence. These are unspeakable, undiscoverable, unsearchable; only believe in simplicity and yet with firmness, that God is and shall be seen as he has been, since God is immutable.

Who then, is God? He is the father, Son and Holy Spirit, one God. Seek no farther concerning God; for those who wish to know the great deep must first view the natural world. For knowledge of the Trinity is properly likened to the depths of the sea, according to that saying of the Sage, and the great deep, who shall fathom it? Since, just as the depth of the sea is invisible to human sight, even so the Godhead of the Trinity is found to be unknowable by human senses. And thus if, I say, a man wishes to know what he ought to believe, let him not think that he understands better by speech than by believing; because when he seeks it, knowledge of the godhead will recede farther than it was.

Therefore seek the supreme wisdom, not in verbal debate, but by the perfection of a good life, not with the tongue but with the faith that issues from singleness of heart, not with that which is gathered from the guests of a learned irreligion. If then you seek the unutterable by discussion, he will fly farther from you than he was before. If you seek by faith, wisdom shall stand in her accustomed station at the gate, and where she dwells she shall at least in part be seen. But then is she also truly in some measure attained, when the invisible is believed in a manner that passes understanding; for God must be believed invisible as he is, though he be partly seen by the pure heart.

Responsorial. *Ps. 35, 6 – 7; Rm. 11, 33*

R: Lord, your grace is in heaven, your faithfulness till the clouds; * your justice is like the highest mountains, your judgement like the great abyss.

V: O profoundness of riches, wisdom and the science of God! How inscrutable are your judgements!

R: your justice is like the highest mountains, your judgement like the great abyss.

Gospel. *Mt. 22: 1 – 14*

Call all those whom you find to the wedding.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And again Jesus spoke to them in parables, saying, "The kingdom of heaven may be compared to a king who gave a marriage feast for his son, and sent his servants to call those who were invited to the marriage feast; but they would not come. Again he sent other servants, saying, 'Tell those who are invited, Behold, I have made ready my dinner, my oxen and my fat calves are killed, and everything is ready; come to the marriage feast.' But they made light of it and went off, one to his farm, another to his business, while the rest seized his servants, treated them shamefully, and killed them.

The king was angry, and he sent his troops and destroyed those murderers and burned their city. Then he said to his servants, 'The wedding is ready, but those invited were not worthy. Go therefore to the thoroughfares, and invite to the marriage feast as many as you find.' And those servants went out into the streets and gathered all whom they found, both bad and good; so the wedding hall was filled with guests. "But when the king came in to look at the guests, he saw there a man who had no wedding garment; and he said to him, 'Friend, how did you get in here without a wedding garment?' And he was speechless. Then the king said to the attendants, 'Bind him hand and foot, and cast him into the outer darkness; there men will weep and gnash their teeth.'

For many are called, but few are chosen."

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 3: 14 – 21*

Prayer of Paul so that the faithful may know the love of Christ.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

For this reason I bow my knees before the Father, from whom every family in heaven and on earth is named:

That according to the riches of his glory he may grant you to be strengthened with might through his Spirit in the inner man, and that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith; that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may have power to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth, and to know the love of Christ which surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled with all the fullness of God.

Now to him who by the power at work within us is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus to all generations, forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Ep. 3, 20. 21; Gal. 1, 4*

R: To him who has the power to do much more than we can ask him to do,
* to him glory in the Church and in Christ Jesus for all generations, forever and ever!

V: Christ has given himself for our sins, according to the will of our God and Father.

R: to him glory in the Church and in Christ Jesus for all generations, forever and ever!

Second Reading. *Disc. 21 on the Last Supper.*

In his last discourse Christ consolidates more strongly the love in the heart of his disciples with word and with example.

A reading from the “Discourses” of the blessed Martin of Lione, monk.

The oblation of the body of Christ is renewed everyday, even though Christ has died only once, because every day we fall into sins, without

which we cannot live because of the weakness of our flesh.

In the species of the bread Christ wants to indicate his body, because he is “the living bread come down from heaven” (Jn. 6, 51), and in the species of the bread he also wants to show us the union of the body with the head, as the Apostle says: “Because there is only one bread, we, though being many, are only one body: all of us in fact participate of the unique bread” (1 Cor. 10, 17). As in fact from many grains of wheat are formed only one bread, in the same way through the unity of the faith, hope and charity, from different members we become only one body of Christ.

Therefore he who desires to be united to the body of Christ as a living member, participates with the others of the unique heavenly bread that the Lord has broken and distributed.

He, in fact wants that which constitutes them only one thing should be shared by all, when he says: Take it, to become one, eat all of you the same sacrament; “do this in memory of me” (Lk. 22, 19); so that receiving his body and his blood we will make a memory of his passion in such a way that, as he died for us, so also we, if it is necessary, will die for him.

The same happens for the chalice, that is called the new covenant, that is new promise, because through that blood he did not promise temporal but eternal goods; therefore this commemoration has to be renewed until he returns, that is to say until the end of times, when he will come for the judgement.

Therefore, my dear brothers, because the Lord wants us to receive his body and become participants of it in order to keep the unity, if someone separates himself from it by falling into anger, hate or discord, he does not receive worthily the body of Christ, nor can his participation unite him to Christ. In fact the bond of charity unites the many, while discord and hate divide that which is one.

Keep vigil attentively therefore, brothers, so that the poison of discord may not generate hate in the midst of you, and in this way corrupt and destroy in you the weakness of charity.

Turn your gaze to your head, and have present always the price of your redemption.

Christ has saved us only because of love, as the Apostle says: “ God, rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he has loved us, from dead that we were because of sin, has made us revive with Christ: through grace in fact you have been saved” (Ep. 2, 4 5). Thus, “when we were

enemies, we have been reconciled with God through the death of his Son. 5, 10). “No one has a greater love than this: to give his life for his own friends” (Jn. 15, 13).

Above all Christ had an even greater love, because he did not die for his friends, but for his enemies; in fact, while we were still enemies, we were reconciled with God through his death: “He died, just for the unjust” (1 Pt. 3, 18).

Now who is disposed to die for an unjust? (cfr. Rm. 5, 7) No one. For this, before teaching us about love with words, Christ shows it to us, and after having exhorted us many times to love, in the final discourse he consolidates more strongly love in the hearts of the disciples with word and example.

Responsorial. *Jn. 17, 20 – 21; Jer. 32, 38. 39*

R: I pray for those who because of your word will believe in me; * so that all will be only one thing. As you, Father, are in me and I in you, may they also be only one thing in us.

V: They will be my people and I will be their God. I will give them only one heart and only one way of behaving.

R: so that all will be only one thing. As you, Father, are in me and I in you, may they also be only one thing in us.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 8: 5 – 9: 10*

Consolation of the wise man.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

He who obeys a command will meet no harm, and the mind of a wise man will know the time and way.

For every matter has its time and way, although man's trouble lies heavy upon him. For he does not know what is to be, for who can tell him how it will be? No man has power to retain the spirit, or authority over the day of death; there is no discharge from war, nor will wickedness deliver those who are given to it. All this I observed while applying my mind to all that is done under the sun, while man lords it over man to his hurt.

Then I saw the wicked buried; they used to go in and out of the holy place, and were praised in the city where they had done such things. This also is vanity. Because sentence against an evil deed is not executed speedily, the heart of the sons of men is fully set to do evil. Though a sinner does evil a hundred times and prolongs his life, yet I know that it will be well with those who fear God, because they fear before him; but it will not be well with the wicked, neither will he prolong his days like a shadow, because he does not fear before God. There is a vanity which takes place on earth, that there are righteous men to whom it happens according to the deeds of the wicked, and there are wicked men to whom it happens according to the deeds of the righteous. I said that this also is vanity.

And I commend enjoyment, for man has no good thing under the sun but to eat and drink, and enjoy himself, for this will go with him in his toil through the days of life which God gives him under the sun.

When I applied my mind to know wisdom, and to see the business that is done on earth, how neither day nor night one's eyes see sleep; then I saw all the work of God, that man cannot find out the work that is done under the sun. However much man may toil in seeking, he will not find it out; even though a wise man claims to know, he cannot find it out.

But all this I laid to heart, examining it all, how the righteous and the wise and their deeds are in the hand of God; whether it is love or hate man does not know. Everything before them is vanity,

Since one fate comes to all, to the righteous and the wicked, to the good and the evil, to the clean and the unclean, to him who sacrifices and him who does not sacrifice. As is the good man, so is the sinner; and he who swears is as he who shuns an oath. This is an evil in all that is done under the sun, that one fate comes to all; also the hearts of men are full of evil, and madness is in their hearts while they live, and after that they go to the dead. But he who is joined with all the living has hope, for a living dog is better than a dead lion. For the living know that they will die, but the dead know nothing, and they have no more reward; but the memory of them is lost. Their love and their hate and their envy have already perished, and they have no more forever any share in all that is done under the sun.

Go, eat your bread with enjoyment, and drink your wine with a merry heart; for God has already approved what you do.

Let your garments be always white; let not oil be lacking on your head.

Enjoy life with the wife whom you love, all the days of your vain life which he has given you under the sun, because that is your portion in life and in your toil at which you toil under the sun. Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might; for there is no work or thought or knowledge or wisdom in Sheol, to which you are going.

Responsorial. *cfr. 1 Cor. 2, 9 – 10; Qo. 8, 17*

R: What the eye has not seen, nor the ear heard, nor has ever entered into the human mind that is what God has prepared for those whom he loves. * To us God has revealed it through the Holy Spirit, who scrutinises the mysteries of God.

V: Of all the work of God man cannot discover the reasons.

R: To us God has revealed it through the Holy Spirit, who scrutinises the mysteries of God.

Second Reading. *Book 8, 6*

My soul exults in the Lord.

A reading from the “Explanations on Ecclesiastes” of St. Gregory of Agrigento, bishop.

“Come, eat your bread with enjoyment, and drink your wine with a merry heart; for God has already approved of what you do. Let your garments all be white; let not oil be lacking on your head.

If we wished to explain the meaning of this saying in the obvious and literal sense, we could say, appropriately enough, that it seems to be a righteous counsel whereby the Preacher urges us to adopt a simple style of living and adhere to the teachings of a sincere faith in God so that we may eat our bread with enjoyment and drink wine with a merry heart. He wants us not to fall into evil talk or to have anything to do with crooked ways of speech. Instead, our thoughts should be of the things that are right, and, in so far as it is proper we should, with compassion and generosity, help beggars and the needy. In short, we should give ourselves to the duties and deeds that give pleasure to God himself.

However, the spiritual meaning carries our thoughts up to higher things and teaches us to consider the heavenly and mystical bread that came

down from heaven and brought life to the world; and to drink the spiritual wine with a merry heart, that wine which flowed from the side of the true vine at the time of his sufferings that saved us. Of these, the gospel of our salvation says. "And when Jesus had taken bread and had blessed it, he said, to his disciples and apostles, "take and eat; this is my body that is broken for you so that sins may be forgiven"; and in the same way with the cup saying, "Drink from this all of you, this is the blood of the new covenant that is shed for you and for many so that sins may be forgiven." They who eat this bread and drink this mystical wine are indeed gladdened and exult and can cry out, "You have given joy to our hearts."

Moreover, it seems to me that Christ our Saviour, the subsistent Wisdom of God, gave another meaning to this same bread and same wine in the book of Proverbs as well, when he said, "Come, eat of my bread and drink of the wine I have mixed for you," referring to our mystical sharing in the Word. It is the glory of those who do so share that at all times their clothing, that is the works of light, shine brightly as the light, in accordance with what the Lord said in the gospels, "Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and give glory to your Father who is in heaven." Their heads too, will be seen to overflow perpetually with oil, that is, with the Spirit of truth who protects and defends from all the harm of sin.

Responsorial. *Ps. 15, 8 – 9. 5*

R: The Lord is at my right hand, I cannot waver; * for this my heart rejoices, my soul exults.

V: The Lord is my inheritance and chalice:

R: for this my heart rejoices, my soul exults.

Gospel. *Mt. 22: 34 – 40*

Love the Lord your God, and your neighbour as yourself.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

When the Pharisees heard that he had silenced the Sad'ducees, they came together. And one of them, a lawyer, asked him a question, to test him. "Teacher, which is the great commandment in the law?" And he said to him, "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind. This is the great and first commandment.

And a second is like it; you shall love your neighbour as yourself. On these two commandments depend all the law and the prophets."

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 4: 1 – 16*

The Body of Christ is constructed in unity.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, beg you to lead a life worthy of the calling to which you have been called, with all lowliness and meekness, with patience, forbearing one another in love, eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. There is one body and one Spirit, just as you were called to the one hope that belongs to your call, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of us all, who is above all and through all and in all.

But grace was given to each of us according to the measure of Christ's gift. Therefore it is said, "When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men."

(In saying, "He ascended," what does it mean but that he had also descended into the lower parts of the earth? He who descended is he who also ascended far above all the heavens, that he might fill all things.) And his gifts were that some should be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, some pastors and teachers, to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ;

So that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the cunning of men, by their craftiness in deceitful wiles. Rather, speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ, from whom the whole body, joined and knit together by every joint with which it is supplied, when each part is working properly, makes bodily growth and builds itself up in love.

Responsorial. *Ep. 4, 4. 5; Col. 1., 12*

R: Only one body, only one spirit, as only one is the hope to which we have been called. * Only one Lord, only one faith, only one baptism.

V: Let us give thanks with joy to the Father who has made it possible to participate in the destiny of the saints in light.

R: Only one Lord, only one faith, only one baptism.

Second Reading. *Book 4, c. 6*

Behold which sure hope of salvation has been given to the believers.

A reading from the treatise “On Matthew” of St. Pascasio Ratberto, abbot.

If really you are united to the body of Christ, all the others together will assume you in their prayers, and at the same time they will pray so that in you will be fulfilled the will of the Father. For this the unity must not be an object of little consideration, nor should such a firm communion in Christ be held in such little account in which one is the voice of all, and all united in one unique faith possess God in the heart, love him with the same charity and already enjoy him through the same hope; and all together ask and search for but only one thing and knock on the same door of goodness.

Nothing therefore is more valid, richer in grace, more convenient, than that all are only one thing, and all keep vigil on each other, just as each one looks after all, so that all together are found one in Christ. It is exactly in the name of this faith, of this hope and of this love, that he teaches that no one of the faithful should separate himself from that unity.

No one therefore should despair of obtaining from the Father that which the only begotten Son teaches us to ask; no one should leave out because of slothfulness the works that are proper of the children, as he teaches us. This is the power that he has given to men, to become children of God (cfr. Jn. 1,13).

For this he precedes the work of power, because from it comes the adoption of our liberty. For this he gives us the boldness of praying with the prayer that he gave and taught us, so that the grace could make up for our insufficiency. For this every time that one of us, even though far away from the others and hidden in the most remote places, calls God with the name of the Father, he understands that the gift of such a great grace is conceded not separately to the single individuals, but to all the community of men.

No one therefore should glory in saying: My Father who are in heaven, but “Our Father” (Mt. 6, 9), because that expression belongs only to Christ of whom God is the Father in a unique way.

For this in another place he says expressively: “I go up to my Father”, then he adds, “and your Father” (Jn. 20, 17). With these words he indicates with sufficient distinction that to him should be given a special glory since he is the Son by nature, while to all the others together is conceded freely the grace of adoption as children. It is manifested therefore in the first case the consubstantialization of the nature, in the other the goodness of the Lord, while both enjoy in common the name of paternity.

In this way we are taught that in so much as we are washed by the same water of baptism, we have to be all brothers in him, and reciprocally united by the bond of fraternity. Look how the prayer that the heavenly master of life has taught us should be esteemed sure and holy; look how much we can be blessed, if we keep it not only proclaiming it with the mouth, but also living it with faithfulness; and look what sure hope of salvation is given to the believers, how great is the love that the Creator diffuses on us, how infinite is the mercy and goodness that is poured out on us, what abundant grace and what gift of trust is conceded to us: precisely us, who have not been worthy servants, dare to call God with the name of Father.

It is therefore necessary that we live and behave ourselves as sons of God, in order to demonstrate with works and with our way of living, of being really that which we are called.

Responsorial. *Ep. 4, 1. 3. 4; Rm. 15, 5. 6*

R: I exhort you to behave in a manner that is worthy of the vocation that you have received, trying to conserve the unity of the Spirit by means of the bonds of peace. * As only one is the hope to which you have been called, that of your vocation.

V: May God give you the same sentiments towards one another, so that with only one soul and only one voice you may render glory to God.

R: As only one is the hope to which you have been called, that of your vocation.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Eccl. 11: 7 – 12: 14*

Sentences on old age.

A reading from the book of Ecclesiastes.

Light is sweet, and it is pleasant for the eyes to behold the sun. For if a man lives many years, let him rejoice in them all; but let him remember that the days of darkness will be many. All that comes is vanity.

Rejoice, O young man, in your youth, and let your heart cheer you in the days of your youth; walk in the ways of your heart and the sight of your eyes. But know that for all these things God will bring you into judgment.

Remove vexation from your mind, and put away pain from your body; for youth and the dawn of life are vanity.

Remember also your Creator in the days of your youth, before the evil days come, and the years draw nigh, when you will say, "I have no pleasure in them"; before the sun and the light and the moon and the stars are darkened and the clouds return after the rain; in the day when the keepers of the house tremble, and the strong men are bent, and the grinders cease because they are few, and those that look through the windows are dimmed, and the doors on the street are shut; when the sound of the grinding is low, and one rises up at the voice of a bird, and all the daughters of song are brought low; they are afraid also of what is high, and terrors are in the way; the almond tree blossoms, the grasshopper drags itself along and desire fails; because man goes to his eternal home, and the mourners go about the streets; before the silver cord is snapped, or the golden bowl is broken, or the pitcher is broken at the fountain, or the wheel broken at the cistern, and the dust returns to the earth as it was, and the spirit returns to God who gave it.

Vanity of vanities, says the Preacher; all is vanity.

Besides being wise, the Preacher also taught the people knowledge, weighing and studying and arranging proverbs with great care. The Preacher sought to find pleasing words, and uprightly he wrote words of truth.

The sayings of the wise are like goads, and like nails firmly fixed are the collected sayings which are given by one Shepherd.

My son, beware of anything beyond these. Of making many books there is no end, and much study is a weariness of the flesh.

The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God, and keep his commandments; for this is the whole duty of man. For God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil.

Responsorial. *cfr. Ps. 70, 17. 9; 15, 11*

R: You have instructed me, O God, from my youth; today I still proclaim your prodigies. * In the time of my old age you will not repel me.

V: You will give me fullness of joy in your presence, sweetness without end at your right hand.

R: In the time of my old age you will not repel me.

Second Reading. *Book 10, 2*

Draw near to the Lord and you will be illuminated.

A reading from the “Explanations on the Ecclesiastes” of St. Gregory of Agrigento, bishop.

“Light” says the Preacher, “is sweet, and it is pleasant for the eyes to behold the sun. For if the light were taken away the world would be unadorned and life would be lifeless. Which is why Moses, who saw God, said, “And God saw the light and said it was good.” Here it is fitting for us to think of that great, true, eternal light that enlightens every man coming into the world,” namely Christ our Saviour, the Redeemer of the world, who was made man and came to the last extremity of the human condition. Of him the prophet David says,” Sing to God, sing praises to his name; lift up a song to him who rides upon the clouds; his name is the Lord, exult before him.”

He, too, called the light sweet and foretold that it would be good to see with the eyes the sun of glory, he who in the time of his divine incarnation said, “I am the light of the world; he who follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.” And again, “This is judgement, that the light has come into the world.” In this way, by means of the light of the sun that we see with our bodily eyes, he foretold the spiritual Sun of justice. That was indeed most sweet for those who were found worthy to be taught by him and to see him with their own eyes as any man, living and dealing with men, even though he was not just any man.

He was indeed the true God and hence brought it about that the blind saw, the lame walked, the deaf heard, he cleansed those afflicted with leprosy, and by a simple command called the dead back to life.

But now it is most sweet to gaze on him with the eyes of the spirit and to contemplate and ponder over his divine beauty that is not possible

for man to see. Then, by means of this communion and mutual sharing, to be enlightened and adorned; to be filled with the sweetness of the spirit and clothed in sanctity; to attain to understanding and finally to be filled with divine exultation which lasts all the days of this present life. The wise Preacher made this point when he said, "For if a man live many years, let him rejoice in them all." Clearly, for those who gaze on him, the Son of justice is the source of all joy. Of him David the prophet said, "Let them exult before God; let them be jubilant with joy!" and again, "Rejoice in the Lord, O you righteous! Praise befits the upright."

Responsorial. *Ps. 33, 4. 6; cfr. Col. 1, 12 – 13*

R: Glorify the Lord with me, together let us exalt his name. * Look at him and be radiant.

V: He has admitted us to the glory of the saints in light, he has freed us from the power of darkness.

R: look at him and be radiant.

Gospel. *Mt. 23: 1 – 12*

They say and do not do.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then said Jesus to the crowds and to his disciples, "The scribes and the Pharisees sit on Moses' seat; so practice and observe whatever they tell you, but not what they do; for they preach, but do not practice. They bind heavy burdens, hard to bear, and lay them on men's shoulders; but they themselves will not move them with their finger. They do all their deeds to be seen by men; for they make their phylacteries broad and their fringes long, and they love the place of honour at feasts and the best seats in the synagogues, and salutations in the market places, and being called rabbi by men.

But you are not to be called rabbi, for you have one teacher, and you are all brethren. And call no man your father on earth, for you have one Father, who is in heaven. Neither be called masters, for you have one master, the Christ. He who is greatest among you shall be your servant; whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.

